Name it exactly

Name the feeling, find the word.
Say it so it's heard.

draft rhyme



I find the exact word for what I feel. Not just bad. Annoyed? Embarrassed? Let down? Sometimes it's two at once.

EXACT

Try it tonight

Think of one small thing that bugged you this week. Say the first word that comes. Probably bad, or mad. Now find a sharper word. Annoyed? Embarrassed? Left out? Let down? Jealous? Nervous? Pick one. If two fit, say both. Say it out loud: 'I felt embarrassed, and a bit annoyed.' Now give it a number from 1 to 10. That's it. The word is a tool, not a grade.

Scientists noticed that teens who name feelings exactly handle hard days a bit better. Nobody has tested teaching it yet.

Where it came from

In 2018, scientists at Harvard asked 143 people, from age 5 to age 25, how some pictures made them feel. Little kids and grown-ups used clear, separate feeling words. Teens tended to lump their feelings together. Another team in New York followed 233 teens for a year and a half: teens who could name feelings exactly were knocked down less by hard times.

Search:
emotion differentiation teens Nook Somerville

Backup: Long breath out

When I notice _____, I _____.

Pip's moves, chapter 4

Tomorrow: did you try it? did it help?

MADE UP

Chapter 1

Panel one. Pip the Fox, with orange fur, round glasses, a green hoodie with a yellow lightning patch, and red high-top sneakers, shuts the bedroom door with a BANG. The blue sketchbook stays tucked under one arm. Pip drops onto the bed. Everyone is annoying, Pip thinks, and that is all Pip has to say.

Panel two. A warm orange caption box floats over Pip's head. The word in it is EXACT. Pip squints through the round glasses and reads the box slowly, one line at a time.

"Think of one small thing that bugged you this week. Say the first word that comes. Probably bad, or mad. Now find a sharper word. Annoyed? Embarrassed? Left out? Let down? Jealous? Nervous? Pick one. If two fit, say both. Say it out loud: 'I felt embarrassed, and a bit annoyed.' Now give it a number from 1 to 10. That's it. The word is a tool, not a grade."

Panel three. Pip sighs. The first word that comes is not very exact. Pip draws it as a giant hat in the margin of the sketchbook. It is labelled BAD, and it is a hat that fits every head and no head. Pip snorts at the hat.

Pip tries again and looks for a sharper word. Pip picks one that fits, or two if two fit, and says it out loud to the empty room. Then Pip chooses a number from 1 to 10 and keeps it private. The word and the number belong to Pip.

Panel four. Pip's shoulders are still a little tight. The day still has some prickles in it. The move did not fix everything, and the story does not pretend it did. But Pip now has a clear word to hold, and a small thing to do next. Pip opens the blue sketchbook to a fresh page and draws the first box of a new comic.

The end of the strip.

Try it out

Name it exactly

Think of one small thing that bugged you this week. Say the first word that comes. Probably bad, or mad. Now find a sharper word. Annoyed? Embarrassed? Left out? Let down? Jealous? Nervous? Pick one. If two fit, say both. Say it out loud: 'I felt embarrassed, and a bit annoyed.' Now give it a number from 1 to 10. That's it. The word is a tool, not a grade.

One thing to try

say one exact feeling word out loud, or write it on the poster's line.

When I notice _____, I _____.

For you

Why this move

Nook, Sasse, Lambert, McLaughlin and Somerville, Psychological Science, 2018, DOI 10.1177/0956797618773357, PMID 29878880; ages 5 to 25, lab task; fit MECHANISM. Starr and others, Emotion, 2020, DOI 10.1037/emo0000630, PMID 31246045; 233 teens, average age 15.9, followed 1.5 years; fit ADJACENT. Also Zhu 2026 in preschoolers (PMID 41718720, from the 4 to 10 list).

What to say

1. I noticed you looked <feeling>.
2. That makes sense.
3. Want to try the move now, or later?
4. You did the move. What did you notice?

Talk together

Was it one feeling or two at once? Which one was bigger?

When to skip this move

in the loudest part of a meltdown (name it after); never tell the child what they feel, offer a guess; never as a label for the child ("you're an angry kid"); a scary event that really happened goes to Card B, not a poster.

Where it came from

"In 2018, scientists at Harvard asked 143 people, from age 5 to age 25, how some pictures made them feel. Little kids and grown-ups used clear, separate feeling words. Teens tended to lump their feelings together. Another team in New York followed 233 teens for a year and a half: teens who could name feelings exactly were knocked down less by hard times." Search: "emotion differentiation teens Nook Somerville".

MECHANISM, ADJACENT

What the research cannot tell us

these studies watched children; none taught naming and then measured the result.

When to call your child's doctor

- Low mood, sadness or crankiness most of the day, every day, for more than two weeks. Do not wait two weeks if it is severe or getting worse. [A11, 2022-09-12; NIMH children and mental health]
- Big changes in sleep, weight or eating. [A12, 2025-05-20]
- Pulling away from friends and family more than usual. [A12, 2025-05-20; A11, 2022-09-12]
- Fear or sadness that is extreme or does not let up. [A15, 2026-05-15]
- Any talk of self harm or not wanting to live: call or text 988 now, or chat at 988lifeline.org. Never ignore it. If there is danger right now, call 911. [A12, 2025-05-20; A15, 2026-05-15]
- Puberty signs before age 8 in a girl or before 9 in a boy. [A3, 2019-06-04; A4, 2014-12-19]
- No puberty signs by 13 in a girl or by 14 in a boy. [A3, 2019-06-04; A4, 2014-12-19]
- What to say on the phone: exactly what you saw and heard, and for how long.
- Note: one AAP page still lists an older crisis number. Use 988. [A11, 2022-09-12]